instead on British policy only. Where discussion of Soviet foreign policy towards Asia does occur it is based on work already done by other researchers and is used with the aim of contrasting what British government officials perceived Bolshevik aims in Asia to be, not in understanding what such aims actually were. For the purposes of this work, 'South Asia' will largely refer to Persia, Afghanistan and India, with only brief mention of events in Egypt, Mesopotamia, Turkey, the Transcaucasus, Transcaspia and Turkestan as they pertain to Britain's general international situation. In the same vein, this work does not discuss British imperial policy at large and affairs in Ireland, for example, are not mentioned. Aside from the issue of brevity, the reason for this decision of focus lies in the issues discussed above – namely the influence of the Great Game on the thinking of some British officials regarding Russia, Persia, Afghanistan and India. Persia and Afghanistan are singled out here as they were the two countries in which the Great Game most heavily featured in the nineteenth century, and in which Anglo-Russian conflict continued to occur in the post-war period.

Persia and Afghanistan lay directly between British India and Russia, a highly vulnerable buffer zone in British eyes. In effect, all the issues that Britain faced in its imperial policy at large were compounded in Persia, Afghanistan and India by the threat of Russia looming on the border. Furthermore, this work will argue that British officials themselves viewed this region of the world differently to other areas of imperial interest. For the Indian government, Persia and Afghanistan represented a barrier which was in essence the last line of India's defence; for Great Game thinkers, these two countries were prizes up for grabs in the relentless competition for hegemony in Asia. And if further reason is needed for the choice of Persia, Afghanistan and India for the focus of this work, events in these countries in the early twentieth century make them not only interesting but important nations to study. The Persian revolution of 1905 to 1911, the Third Anglo-Afghan War of 1919, the Caliphate agitation and the non-co-operation policy of Gandhi and his followers throughout the 1920s, are just some examples of movements and events which signified the rise of nationalism and pan-Islamism in this region of the world and which directly impacted Britain's imperial interests.